

SDAF Reader's Guide

A practical orientation for first-time readers of SDAF v1.0

Version 1.0 | September 2026 | Raymond du Toit

1. What this guide is (and isn't)

This Reader's Guide is not a summary of SDAF. It's a **navigation tool**.

Its purpose is to help a new reader understand:

- **how the document is structured,**
- **where to begin,**
- **which sections matter for their role,**
- **how the Parts relate to each other,**
- **how to avoid misinterpreting SDAF,**
- **how to read the framework without getting lost.**

It does *not* restate the methodology, lifecycle, or decision logic — those already exist in the Introduction, Executive Summary, and Quick Start Guide.

2. How SDAF is structured (the map)

SDAF is organized into **eight Parts**, grouped into three layers:

Layer 1 — The Method (Parts I–V)

These Parts define *how* an SDAF assessment works.

- **Part I — Foundations:** Terminology, principles, scope, and normative structure.
- **Part II — Lifecycle:** The five-phase sequence every assessment follows.
- **Part III — Measurement:** Boundaries, evidence quality, uncertainty, confidence, traceability.
- **Part IV — Decision-Making:** Evidence sufficiency, stability, hard constraints, decision class.
- **Part V — Lifecycle & Circularity:** Embodied impacts, circularity benefits, allocation, amortization.

Layer 2 — Integrity & Control (Part VI)

Ensures SDAF is applied correctly.

- **Part VI — Governance & Assurance:** Conformance, independence, verification, reproducibility.

Layer 3 — Adoption & Exchange (Parts VII–VIII)

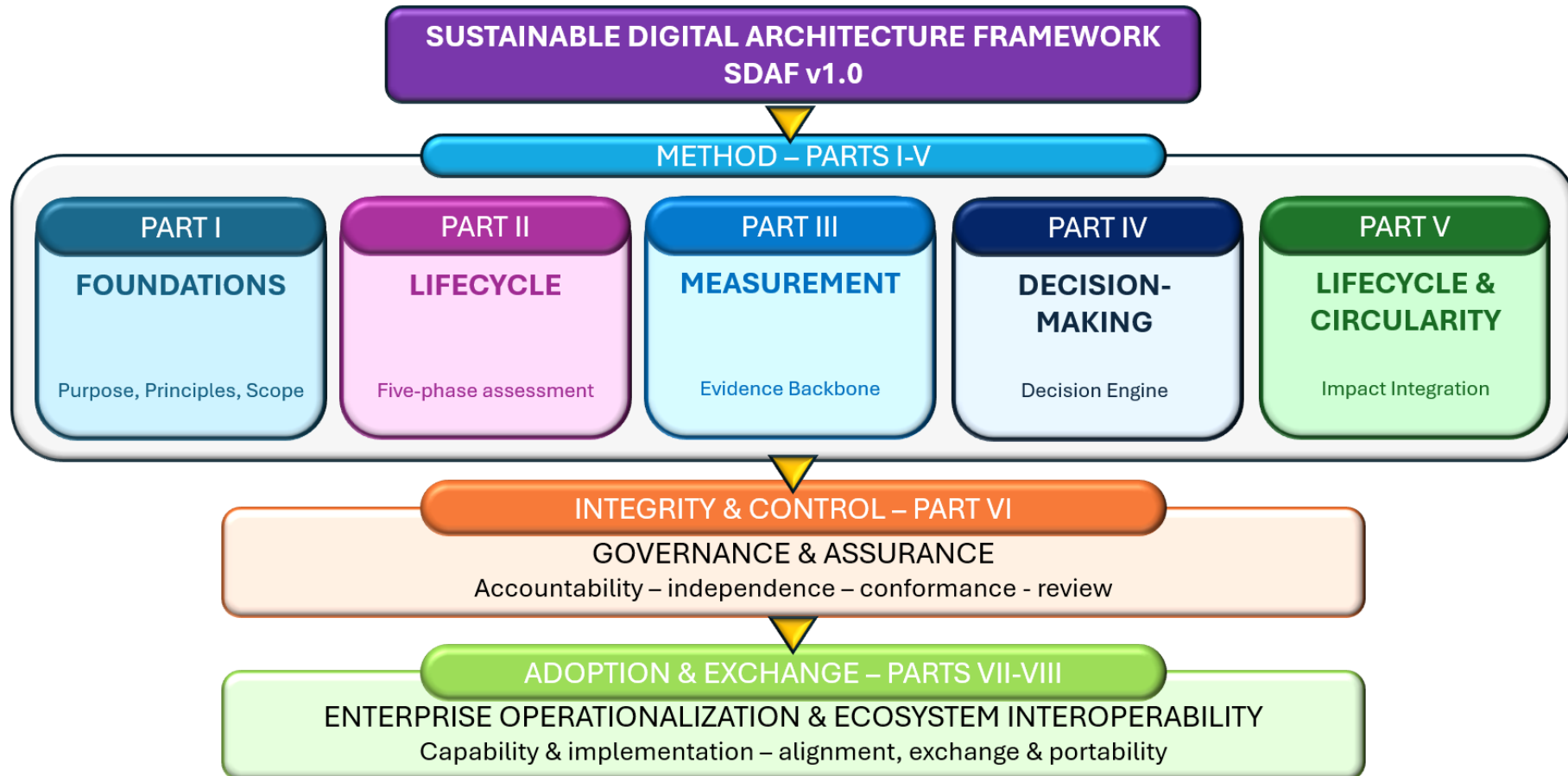
Makes SDAF usable across organizations and ecosystems.

- **Part VII — Enterprise Operationalization:** Roles, systems, telemetry, supplier workflows, capability building.
- **Part VIII — Ecosystem Interoperability:** Evidence exchange, supplier alignment, federated assurance.

This structure is deliberate: **Method → Integrity → Adoption.**

SDAF ARCHITECTURE – PARTS I – VIII

One framework: method, integrity, adoption, exchange



The parts remain distinct; together they form one controlled architecture

Figure 1 — SDAF Architecture (Parts I–VIII)

The overall structure of the Sustainable Digital Architecture Framework, showing how Method, Integrity, and Adoption layers form one controlled architecture.

3. How to read SDAF depending on your role

Use the pathways below to identify the sections most relevant to your responsibilities.

If you are an executive or decision authority

Read:

- Introduction
- Executive Summary
- Part IV (Decision-Making)
- Part VI (Governance & Assurance)

Purpose: understand how SDAF makes decisions defensible.

If you are an architect or engineer

Read:

- Quick Start Guide
- Part II (Lifecycle)
- Part III (Measurement)
- Part IV (Decision-Making)
- Part V (Lifecycle & Circularity)

Purpose: understand how to compare options consistently.

If you are a sustainability practitioner

Read:

- Part III (Measurement)
- Part V (Lifecycle & Circularity)
- Annex VIII-A (Enterprise Environmental Information Interfaces)

Purpose: understand evidence quality, uncertainty, and lifecycle treatment.

If you are in procurement or finance

Read:

- Executive Summary
- Part II (Lifecycle)
- Part III (Measurement)
- Part V (Lifecycle & Circularity)
- Annex VIII-A (Enterprise Environmental Information Interfaces)

Purpose: understand supplier evidence, service boundaries, and lifecycle consequences.

If you are in governance, risk, or assurance

Read:

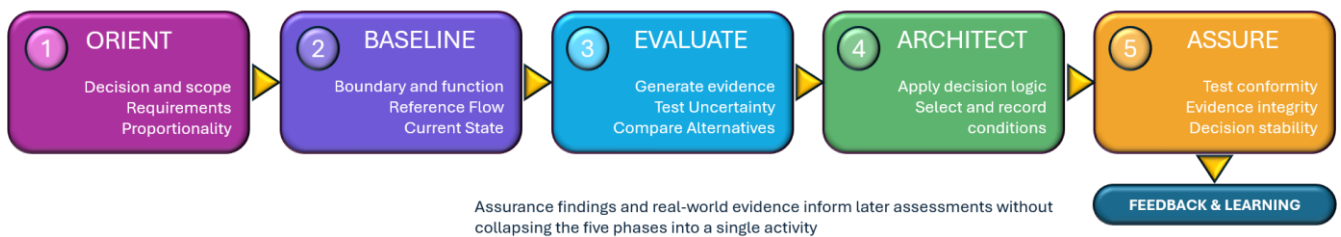
- Part VI (Governance & Assurance)
- Part IV (Decision-Making)
- Part III (Measurement)

Purpose: understand conformance, independence, and review triggers.

This prevents readers from trying to digest the entire methodology at once.

SDAF FIVE-PHASE LIFECYCLE

The repeatable backbone of every SDAF assessment



The lifecycle is sequential, but not static.

Each phase produces controlled outputs for the work that follows. Review triggers may reopen an earlier phase when assumptions, evidence, requirements or operating conditions materially change.

CONTROLLED PROGRESSION

EXPLICIT HAND-OFFS

RECORDED RATIONALE

REVIEW WHEN CONDITIONS CHANGE

Figure 2 — SDAF Five-Phase Lifecycle

The repeatable backbone of every SDAF assessment, illustrating the sequential yet adaptive progression from orientation to assurance and learning.

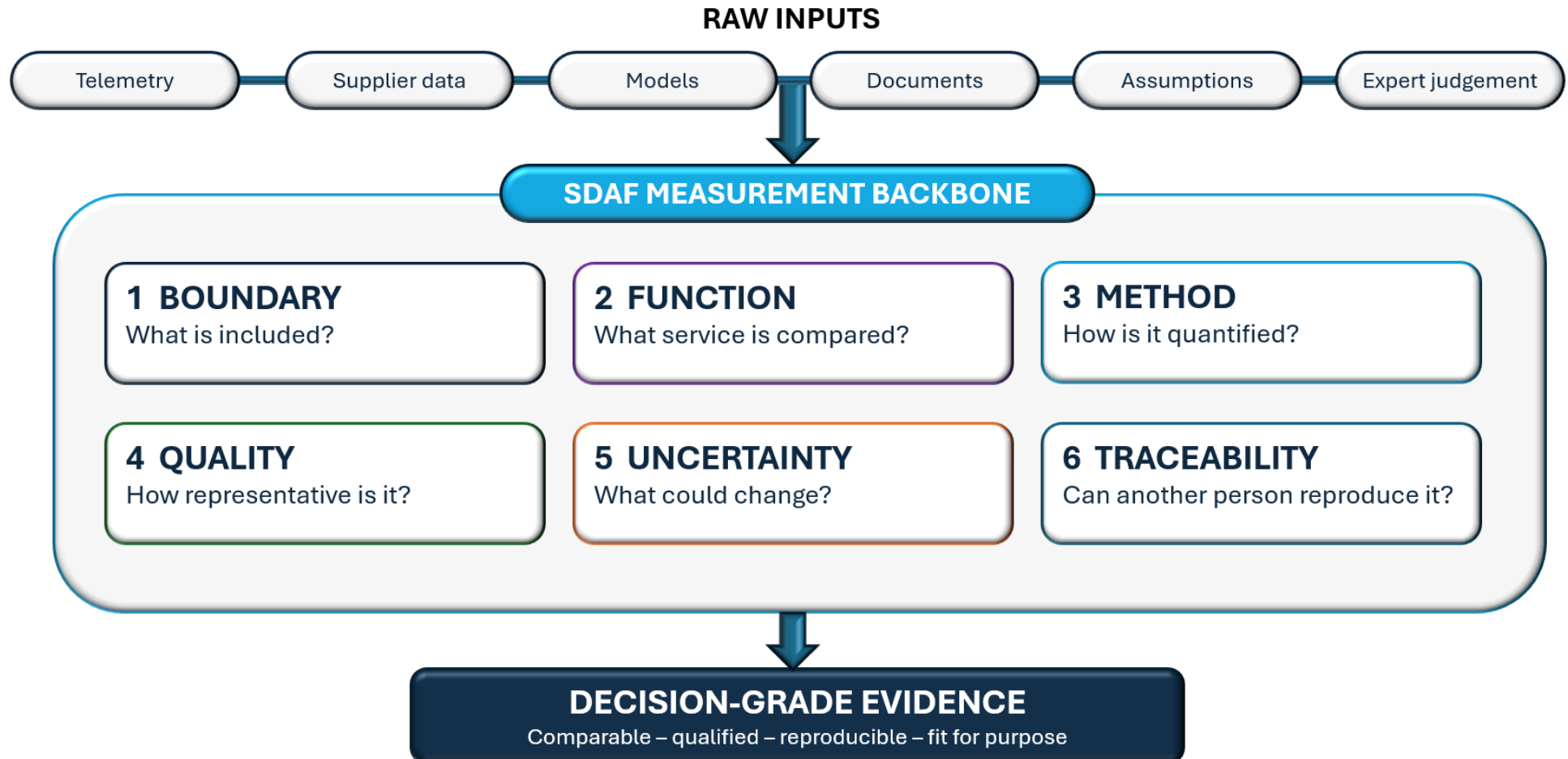
4. How the Parts fit together (the logic chain)

SDAF is not eight separate documents. It is one architecture with a clear flow:

1. **Part I** establishes the common foundation and normative requirements.
2. **Part II** defines the assessment lifecycle.
3. **Part III** establishes the measurement and evidence requirements.
4. **Part IV** governs decision classification and rationale.
5. **Part V** defines how lifecycle and circularity enter the decision.
6. **Part VI** establishes governance and tests conformity with SDAF requirements.
7. **Part VII** integrates SDAF into enterprise practice.
8. **Part VIII** supports evidence exchange and alignment across organizations.

SDAF Measurement Backbone

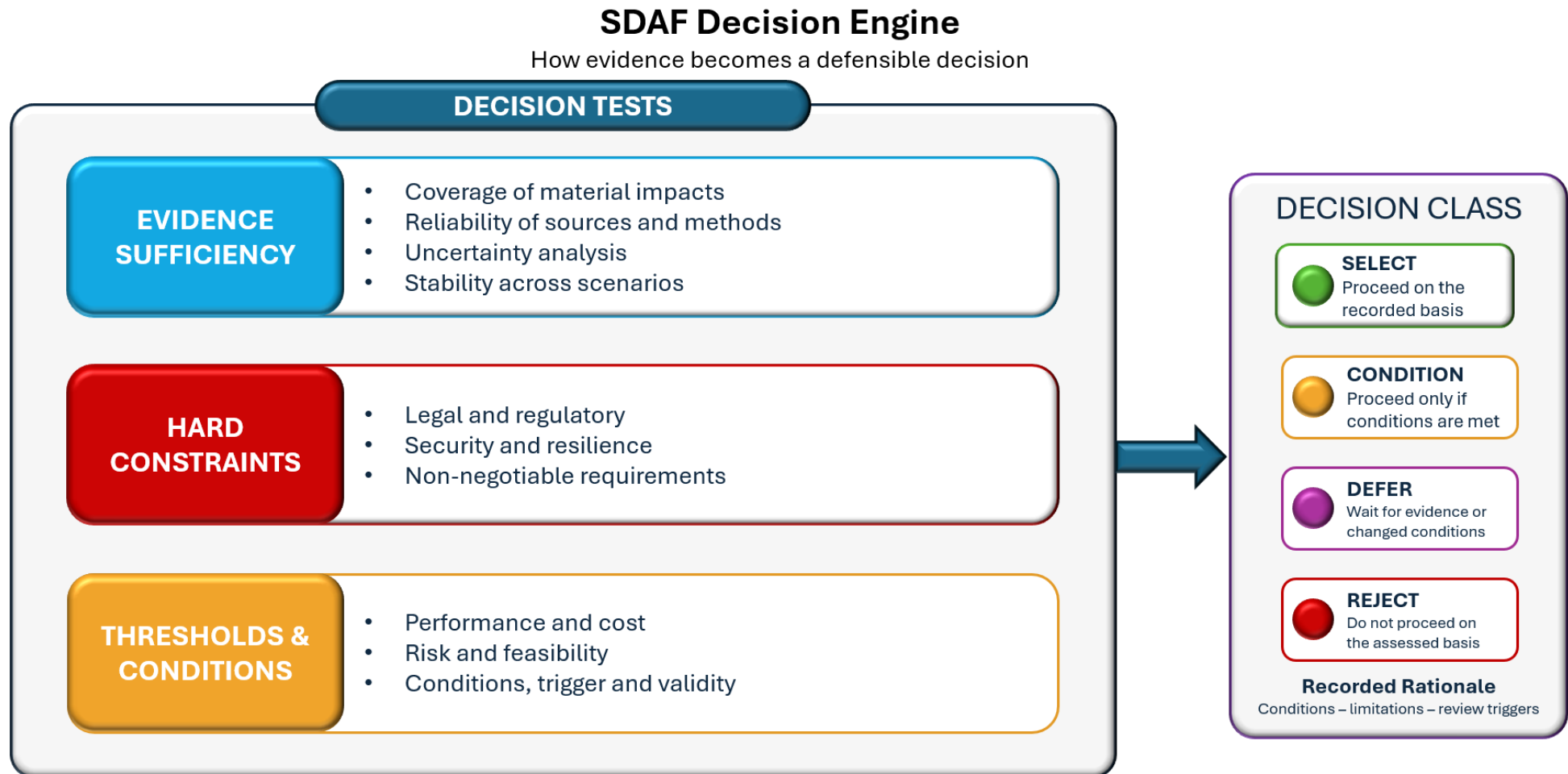
How raw inputs become decision-grade evidence



Numbers become evidence only after explicit measurement controls are applied

Figure 3 — SDAF Measurement Backbone

How raw inputs become decision-grade evidence through controlled measurement boundaries, quality, uncertainty, and traceability checks.



A decision class expresses what the evidence and constraints support – not a sustainability label

Figure 4 — SDAF Decision Engine

The logic that transforms evidence into defensible decisions, showing decision classes and the tests for sufficiency, constraints, and stability.

5. What beginners should watch out for

This section prevents misinterpretation without repeating the Quick Start Guide.

A. SDAF is not a carbon calculator

It is a decision architecture, not a scoring tool.

B. SDAF does not assume the lowest carbon option is best

Trade-offs matter.

C. SDAF does not replace lifecycle assessment

It uses lifecycle evidence within a decision context.

D. SDAF does not override external standards

It governs how they inform decisions.

E. SDAF does not hide uncertainty

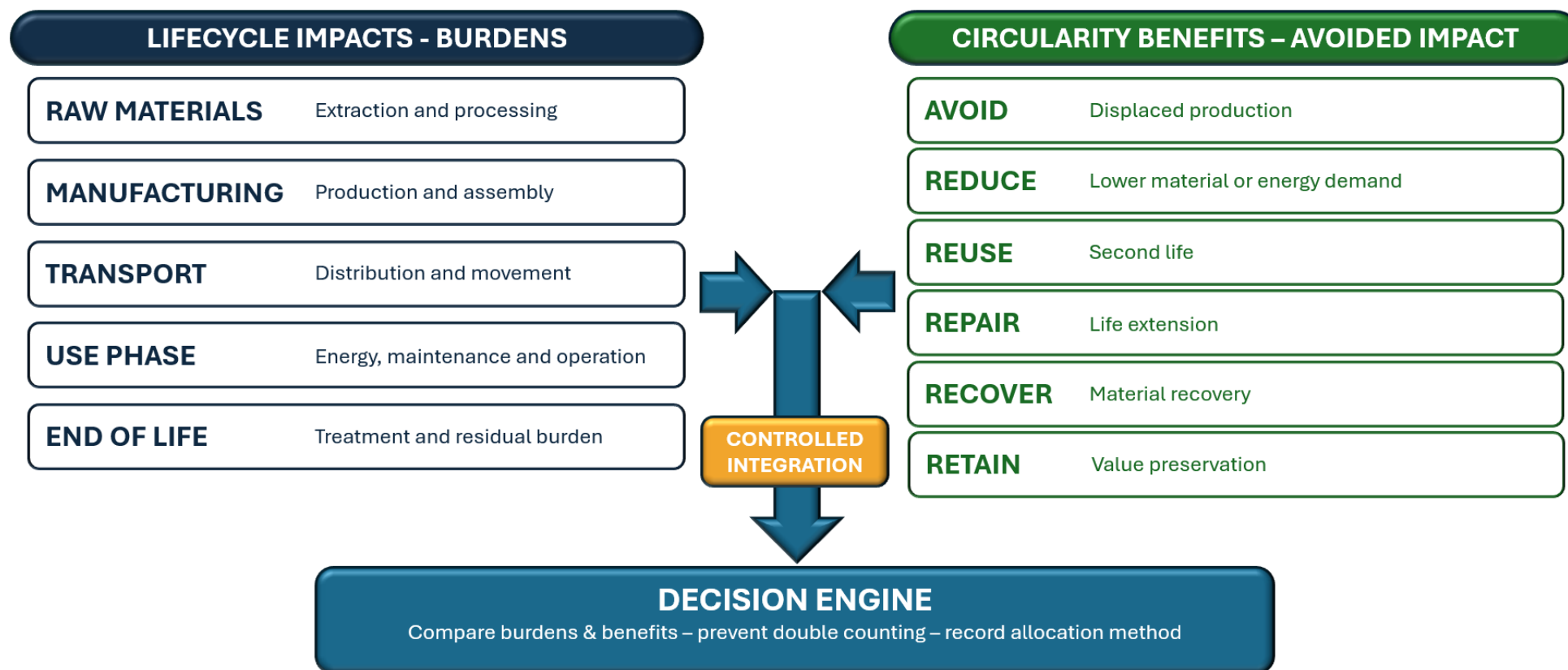
Uncertainty is part of the decision logic.

F. SDAF does not treat governance approval as evidence

Governance protects the method; it does not validate the outcome.

Lifecycle & Circularity Integration

Burdens and benefits remain separate until controlled decision integration



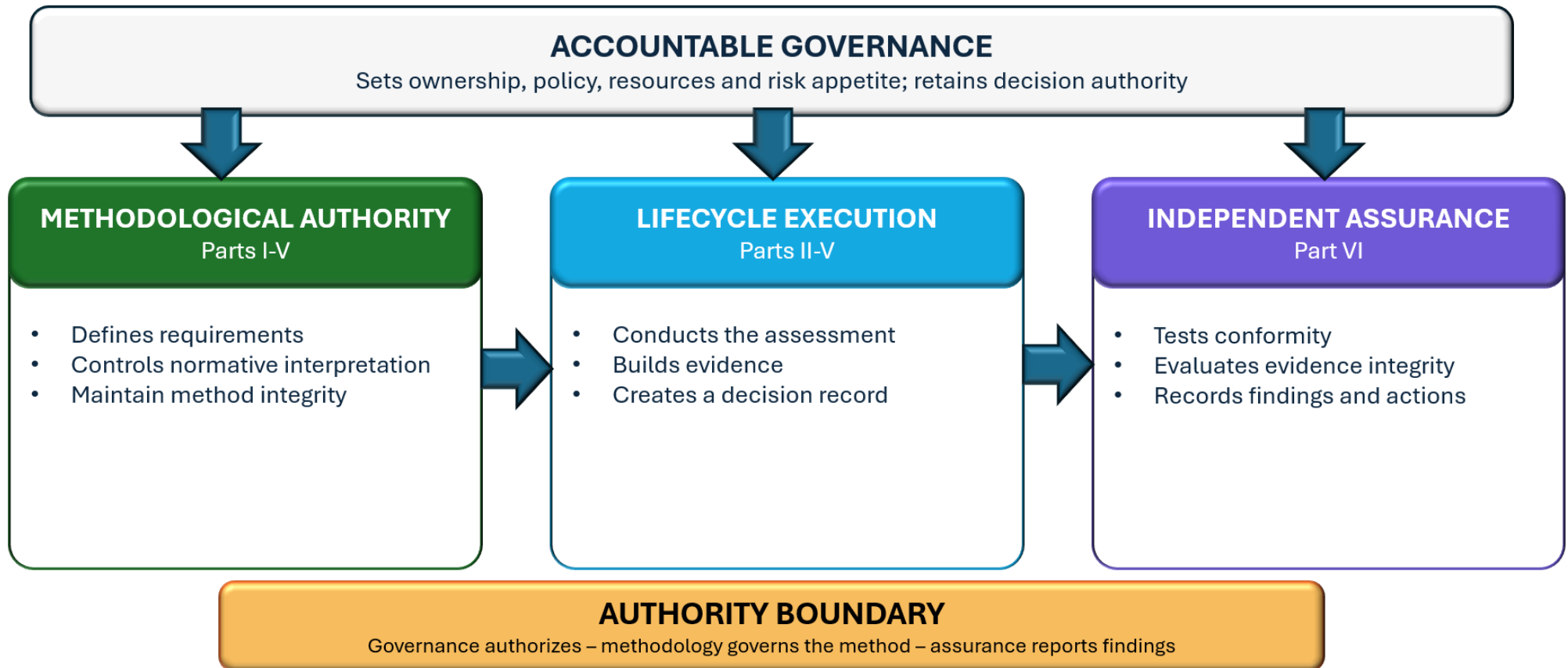
Circularity does not erase lifecycle burden; both remain visible and traceable

Figure 5 — Lifecycle & Circularity Integration

Controlled integration of lifecycle burdens and circularity benefits, ensuring both remain visible and traceable within the decision process.

SDAF Governance & Assurance

Distinct authorities protect methodological integrity



Governance ≠ methodological override. Assurance ≠ decision approval

Figure 6 — SDAF Governance & Assurance

Distinct authorities that protect methodological integrity, clarifying the boundaries between governance, lifecycle execution, and independent assurance.

6. Where to begin (the onboarding path)

A new reader should follow this sequence:

1. **Executive Summary** — understand the purpose.
2. **Introduction** — understand the context.
3. **Reader's Guide** — understand how to navigate.
4. **Quick Start Guide** — understand how to apply SDAF.
5. **Part I** — understand the foundations, scope, principles and normative structure.
6. **Part II** — understand the lifecycle.
7. **Part III** — understand evidence.
8. **Part IV** — understand decisions.
9. **Part V** — understand lifecycle & circularity.
10. **Part VI** — understand assurance.
11. **Parts VII–VIII** — understand enterprise & ecosystem use.

Enterprise Operationalization

SDAF integrates into existing enterprise functions

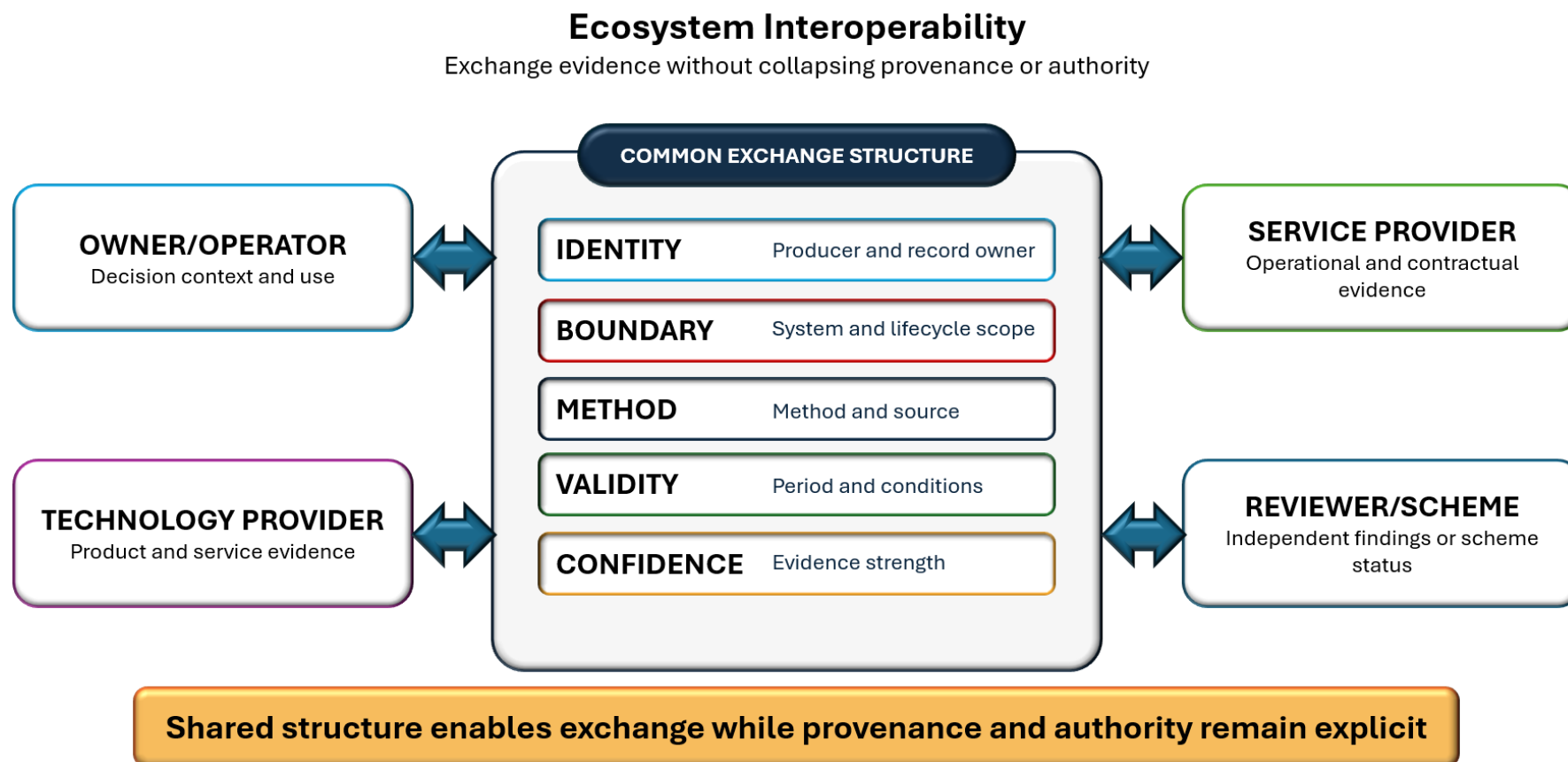


Integrated into normal enterprise decisions – not a parallel process

Each function contributes through its existing authority, records and review points

Figure 7 — Enterprise Operationalization

How SDAF integrates into existing enterprise functions, linking architecture, procurement, operations, sustainability, governance, and assurance through a controlled decision record.



Interoperability enables alignment and portability without turning unlike evidence into the same evidence

Figure 8 — Ecosystem Interoperability

The common exchange structure that enables evidence sharing across organizations while preserving provenance, authority, and confidence.

Framework: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22899663>

Review and contribute: <https://github.com/Raymond-du-Toit/SDAF>